



Vedic Dutta <vedicdutta86@gmail.com>

Second Round of Evaluation for the Platinum Jubilee Innovation Challenge

1 message

Associate Dean 2, Innovation and Entrepreneurship <adeanie2@iitkgp.ac.in>

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To: armanbarik2@gmail.com, pjiitkgp@gmail.com, devesh9413264048@gmail.com, shreyasmishra506@gmail.com, kumarbhanvi@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, harshilindia011@gmail.com, kumardurgesh.web@gmail.com, adarshmishrajnv91@gmail.com, guptachinmay321@gmail.com, abhisar.4601@gmail.com, taksalprakash@gmail.com, mahatokaran002@gmail.com, rakeshms07.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, sunil.rjjj@gmail.com, iamrajadip25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, sriharinеш06.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, prabhatvaidhya2003@gmail.com, alertsgeeta@gmail.com, akashchatterjee.jam@gmail.com, sunandmoon200519@gmail.com, kaushik2008k@gmail.com, hari.vijayan.warrior@gmail.com, ankitkumar27268@gmail.com, ymali5334@gmail.com, aneja.suhaan200725@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, oindrila110304@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, pawan.prajapat9904@gmail.com, sayan.halder.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, shakuntala225@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, chhawariankitgurjar@gmail.com, harsh7890@gmail.com, satyamsubham100@gmail.com, rudranarayan.pr@gmail.com, naveen.chandrakar26@gmail.com, ajitesh.jam@gmail.com, kumardurgesh@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, anoushka.polukonda@gmail.com, dheeraj6122002@gmail.com, anand24_ms.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, deepsingh1312003@gmail.com, sarthisatyam234@gmail.com, aryanrajak@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, utkarsh15407@gmail.com, ag.sparsh01@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, attadarshimeshram@gmail.com, sayandas25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, gpunit6454@gmail.com, vinayarya29@gmail.com, vedantahazra2004@gmail.com, jeevankumarkorra2005@gmail.com, krishnendunayek15@gmail.com, rounakmandal3000@gmail.com, herambwarke25@gmail.com, rautparth576@gmail.com, hbiswas25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, veda.anshu.0806@gmail.com, satakshiappleid09@gmail.com, srijibkarmakar@gmail.com, shashankhaliyala@gmail.com, ggopikamurugan@gmail.com, sanuroy56apd@gmail.com, chamanthsai.biit@gmail.com, baqiramirmerchant.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, p.mayank224@gmail.com, supratim15sarkar@gmail.com, aryandhangar000@gmail.com, harshkesharwani777@gmail.com, aniketbiswas25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, venkateshamgoth3@gmail.com, sujchalchandelkar3@gmail.com, vikramgupta89@gmail.com, jitendrabhati2026@gmail.com, armago1173@gmail.com, rajarshibhar@gmail.com, pc186.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, mehula245@gmail.com, namanyapant2630@gmail.com, shrehanofficial@gmail.com, mridulmittal123@gmail.com, agrawalunnat03@gmail.com, sidg0205@gmail.com, piyushmohanty@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, harsgupta026@gmail.com, dex@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, aravind.m25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, depuparvakar@gmail.com, akshatlathi01@gmail.com, ashutoshsharmawhy@gmail.com, harsh22629@gmail.com, ayushkumarmaurya@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, sairampatnam28.iitkgp@gmail.com, omkar2004@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, aryangujare2125@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, arunitowardnew@gmail.com, luharukapranav@gmail.com, kinnarhalder@gmail.com, arijit25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, sarkarsouvik00005@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, tejasasegaonkar@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, biswadeeproy84@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, jatainkumar7@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, sen.shashwati@gmail.com, palsnehal004@gmail.com, souvikraj100@gmail.com, contact.aakritik@gmail.com, rk2020559.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, anandkumar2013008@gmail.com, dontalasatya1999@gmail.com, soumyajitmukhopadhyay7@gmail.com, shreeyamishra22@gmail.com, joydeepataran@gmail.com, saipalagiri42@gmail.com, agrawal.ayushh786@gmail.com, mohit24.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, hirmanish04@gmail.com, jyotisko25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, pandeysudhanshu2006@gmail.com, samarth0103sharma@gmail.com, suyashkankane@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, harapasadbadajena@gmail.com, pranav.m.pandey43@gmail.com, lakavathsacharan419@gmail.com, malhotra.aryan.a01@gmail.com, matthews27@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, asthanasiddharth2002@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, harthikvarma0.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, guptashiva9679@gmail.com, diotimanag277@gmail.com, sampurnadan0925@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, prathmbamne2002@gmail.com, paramkumar08@gmail.com, premnadh.akkala.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, 009rohinichavan@gmail.com, bnsreenandini.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, lisbanhanaga@gmail.com, adarshkmeher@gmail.com, rajghosh2507@gmail.com, keerthanaveeramalla29.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, gauriatole2311@gmail.com, atulyasharan29@gmail.com, rhythm1920@gmail.com, dnyaneshwarisvghare@gmail.com, varshamgupta12@gmail.com, shubhamk25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, devrajsarkar78525@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, sarthakdpsdhn@gmail.com, koyenachowdhury02@gmail.com, dhruv.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, kumarjitray9@gmail.com, uditnarayanbera25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, shubharuidas123@gmail.com, rupeshdevata@gmail.com, rushikeshsg9096@gmail.com, singh04srajan1125@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, prtkkshkram@gmail.com, krdhirendra2006@gmail.com, eisstudentpreneur2025@gmail.com, priyalpatre86314@gmail.com, akyushumar@gmail.com, ansariarshmohammad2004@gmail.com, omkar.amaesi.iitkgp@gmail.com, yograjlodhi4872@gmail.com, shariqjamil260@gmail.com, khushsamota@gmail.com, niishu1303@gmail.com, ankita9525@gmail.com, nikhil181yadav@gmail.com, digitaltwinsric@gmail.com, snehalxi@gmail.com, nanditadatta668@gmail.com, divvelarakesh1994@gmail.com, kumarnishant262626@gmail.com, ayushgaurav0104@gmail.com, subhambarmar733127@gmail.com, anoraankur@gmail.com, bipasharoy291225@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, rkumaryadav@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, yashawinitm@gmail.com, kumaradarshsingh131@gmail.com, vangalaakshayreddy@gmail.com, anishgupta.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, arunadithyan25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, sahilkumar9546585371@gmail.com, vikramkumawat.iitkgp@gmail.com, moitrayani800@gmail.com,

shobhitranjan2005@gmail.com, arjunsankhla6@gmail.com, divyataneja001@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, krishnaashraicho@gmail.com, simhasekhar78@gmail.com, parvchopra07@gmail.com, smaranrajagopal25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, srinjoydas566@gmail.com, khadatkar.meet@gmail.com, vedicdutta86@gmail.com, jyothiraditya.ml@gmail.com, satyaminhe.23@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, taransaxena2811@gmail.com, sahithyamarumudi@gmail.com, barmanjitam@gmail.com, harshchauhan0501.24@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, aviralgoyal25@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, vivekadithyayavaram2005@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, simplisticarya@gmail.com, jyothiraditya29.vc@gmail.com, shivrajpgulve@kgpian.iitkgp.ac.in, v200p4@gmail.com, tvsaikritik@gmail.com
Cc: prajit <prajit@ee.iitkgp.ac.in>

Dear Innovators,

The Second Round of Evaluation for the Platinum Jubilee Innovation Challenge will be conducted within 10th July 2026 and we write to share important details about the process and what is expected of you.

Format of the Second Round

The second round will be conducted in online mode. You will be required to:

- Submit a concise written description of your innovation prior to the evaluation
- Make a live online presentation using ppt before an expert jury panel
- Demonstrate your idea, prototype, or design in action, wherever possible — this is strongly encouraged and will be viewed very favourably by the evaluators

Selection for the Final Round

On the basis of the second round, approximately 100 to 120 innovations will be shortlisted for the Grand Final, which is planned for either the last week of July or the first week of August 2025. Prize announcements will be made on 16th August 2025, as part of IIT Kharagpur's Platinum Jubilee celebrations — making this a particularly special occasion to be part of.

What the Jury Will be Looking For

We want to be transparent about the evaluation criteria so that you can prepare with the right focus. The jury will place greater value on innovations that:

The evaluators are likely to consider the following features on your innovation for grading:

1. Problem Significance and Clarity of Insight

The entry should demonstrate that the team has correctly identified a real, important, and well-defined problem — and that they understand it at a depth beyond the surface. Many student innovations solve problems that are either trivial, already solved, or poorly understood. The evaluator would ask: does this team know exactly who suffers from this problem, why existing solutions fall short, and how large the unmet need actually is? Strong entries show evidence of user research, field observation, or lived experience — not just a clever idea in search of a problem.

2. Originality and Creativity of the Solution

The solution should offer a genuinely novel approach — not merely an incremental improvement on what already exists. This does not mean the technology has to be unprecedented, but the combination of insight, method, and application should be distinctive. Evaluators would look for lateral thinking: has the team reframed the problem in an unexpected way, borrowed a principle from an unrelated domain, or challenged an assumption that others have taken for granted?

3. Technical Feasibility and Scientific Soundness

The proposed solution should be grounded in sound science or engineering. Evaluators would assess whether the underlying principles are valid, whether the team demonstrates command of the relevant technical domain, and whether the proposed approach is realistically achievable within a reasonable timeframe. Ambition is valued, but an entry that violates the laws of physics or ignores well-known technical constraints should be penalised regardless of how compelling the pitch is.

4. Impact Potential — Scale, Depth, and Reach

How many people could benefit, and by how much? A solution that meaningfully improves the lives of a million people scores higher than one that offers a marginal benefit to a small, already-served population. Evaluators would consider both breadth (how many) and depth (how much does it actually change things for each person). Entries addressing underserved communities, environmental challenges, or systemic gaps in health, education, agriculture, or livelihoods should be weighted favourably on this dimension.

5. Prototype Quality and Stage of Development

An idea that has been built, tested, and iterated upon is fundamentally more credible than one that exists only in a deck. Evaluators would assess whether the team has moved from concept to prototype, conducted any form of user testing or field trial, and incorporated feedback into their design. The Technology Readiness Level (TRL) of the solution is a useful framework here — a working prototype that has been tested with real users is worth far more than a beautifully presented simulation.

6. Viability of the Business or Implementation Model

A brilliant innovation that cannot reach the people it is meant to serve is ultimately incomplete. Evaluators would assess whether the team has a credible path to deployment — whether through a startup, a social enterprise, a licensing model, or a public programme. This includes a basic understanding of who will pay for it, how it will be distributed, and what the unit economics look like. Entries that show market awareness, customer discovery, and a realistic go-to-market plan demonstrate the kind of full-stack thinking that distinguishes founders from inventors.

An innovation that is closer to market-readiness and demonstrates measurable impact will be viewed as less risky and will score higher than one that remains at a very early conceptual stage, even if the underlying idea is interesting.

We urge each of you to make as much tangible progress as possible between now and the evaluation. Build. Test. Iterate. If you can show your idea working — even in a simple prototype or proof-of-concept — it will make a decisive difference to how your entry is received.

The jury comprises experienced innovators and investors who have seen thousands of ideas. What distinguishes the best entries is not the sophistication of the presentation — it is the depth of understanding of the problem, the quality of the solution, and the evidence that the team has done the hard work of actually building something.

We look forward to seeing what you have created and wish each one of you the very best.

Sincerely,

Manoj K. Mondal

Associate Dean — Innovation and Entrepreneurship